



Bye Club Nintendo!

After six years from its inception, Nintendo announced its plan to discontinue its loyalty based Club Nintendo Rewards program. <http://dgit.in/ClubNin>

GTX 960 launched

Gamers rejoice! Nvidia has finally launched the GTX 960 that hits the fabled "sweet spot". Read its review in the Bazaar section. http://dgit.in/GTX_960

What will motoring be like in the near future?

As much as we'd wish it were so, car tech around the corner may not involve flying cars and levitating capsules. But realistic visions of the future are strangely more exciting. Don't believe us? Read on...

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If you genuinely understand automotive engineering and technology, there's a good chance that you might find it hard to take any of the futuristic concepts showcased at auto shows seriously. It's the same story every year – auto expos unveiling outlandish ideas touted to revolutionise the motor car as we know it. Yet, the cars that we all drive have remained largely unchanged, save for a few bells and whistles such as keyless entry and voice-activated stereos. Then again, it's hard to improve upon a technology that has been perfected through well over a century of collective human effort.

The electric car is an excellent example illustrating just that. For all practical purposes, it is an unmitigated failure unless paired with an internal combustion engine in a hybrid configuration. Unless, of course, you fancy range anxiety and waiting several hours for a recharge each time the battery runs out. Now, if you plan on arguing about the ecological impact of the internal combustion engine, let's not forget that fact that manufacturing the massive battery pack powering an electric car involves a terrible cocktail of toxic chemicals and a much larger carbon footprint.

More importantly, most of India's electric power generation depends on fossil fuels. So each time you recharge an electric car, do remember that there's no such thing as zero emissions. Now that we have established that electric cars – like most other fancy automotive concepts – are either outright rubbish or simply unten-

able, let's take a look at car tech that may not necessarily seem flashy at the outset, but still has a greater chance of making a difference to the modern car.

Autonomous Vehicles

If there's one thing more powerful than the human desire for excellence and innovation, it's our inherent laziness. That's probably why most science-fiction films are chock full of self-driven cars

ling record of 14 vehicular fatalities per hour. These are statistics recorded in the year 2009, while the fatality rate has been growing at a steady 8 percent over the past decade. As such, India is in dire need of self-driven cars. Either that, or it would probably be a bad idea given our problem with population explosion. It's hard to tell, so you be the judge.

Coming back to the Google Driverless Car project, the endeavour isn't just designed to allow the company to record images of the road, map the streets, and steal our data through home Wi-Fi networks. These prototypes don't stop at the usual array of laser and radar sensors, as well as image-recognition systems. Google



The Honda FCV concept. Beats our politicians promise of water and power by a few years.

levitating several feet in the air even as the passengers drink champagne in the back. Although we're not sure about the levitation bit, several auto manufacturers have been running prototype autonomous vehicles for a while now. As a matter of fact, even non-auto companies have been doing the same.

Case in point: Google's driverless car project has a fleet of robot cars that have cumulatively logged over one lakh kilometres, as of 2014. All that, without killing a single person. That sure beats India's ster-

takes a more network-centric approach that ties in with its existing web-enabled services to "see" and react well beyond visual and sensor range. These smart cars will be able to make the best possible choice according to data on traffic conditions and their ability to synchronise with, say, traffic lights unlike any human or machine for that matter.

It isn't just about safety or optimal navigation. Networked autonomous cars will be able to communicate with one another to perform manoeuvres such as